

Cilantro Grow Guide

For Cilantro Leaves & Coriander Seeds

Quick Rescue • Quick Numbers • Sunlight • Soil • Water • Feeding • Harvesting •
Bolting • Pests • Diseases • Transplanting

Crop name	Cilantro / Coriander
Scientific name	Coriandrum sativum
Main use	Fresh leaves, stems, flowers and dry seeds
Best climate note	Cooler growing conditions give better leaf harvest
WhatsApp support	1 (876) 372-7415

This guide is written for customers growing cilantro plants from small pots, seedlings, trays, or direct seed. It is practical for home gardens, containers, kitchen gardens and small-farm herb production.

1. Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Likely Cause	What To Do First
Plant wilts after planting	Transplant shock, dry root ball, too much sun	Shade for 1-3 days, water gently, avoid strong fertilizer for 7 days.
Leaves turn pale/yellow	Low nitrogen, overwatering, poor light, root stress	Check drainage, give brighter light, feed lightly after plant settles.
Plant gets tall and sends flower stalk	Bolting from heat, age, dry soil, stress	Harvest leaves immediately; pinch flower stalk; plant a new batch for leaves.
Flat leaves change to thin feathery leaves	Plant is moving into flowering/seed stage	Harvest remaining leaves; allow some plants to flower for coriander seed if desired.
Brown leaf tips or scorched leaves	Heat stress, dry soil, fertilizer burn	Give morning sun/afternoon shade, water evenly, avoid overfeeding.
Sticky new growth or curled leaves	Aphids or whiteflies	Spray undersides with water or mild soap; repeat every 3-5 days.
Seedlings cut off near soil	Cutworms	Check soil at night/early morning; use collars; remove worms.
Holes in leaves	Armyworms/caterpillars, beetles, slugs/snails	Check early morning/evening, handpick, remove badly damaged leaves.
Powdery white coating	Powdery mildew	Improve airflow, avoid crowding, remove badly affected leaves.
Dark wet spots on leaves	Bacterial leaf spot or wet foliage disease	Remove affected leaves, avoid overhead watering, improve spacing.

Customer note: cilantro naturally has a short leaf-harvest window in hot weather. When it bolts, it is not always a care failure - it is the crop moving into flowering and seed production.

2. Quick Numbers

Item	Specific Range / Target
Crop type	Annual herb
Plant height before flowering	About 12-18 inches
Flower stalk height	About 2-3 feet
Plant width	About 10-14 inches
Sunlight	Full sun to light shade; in hot areas use morning sun + afternoon shade
Indoor light	6 hours bright window light or 12-16 hours LED/fluorescent light
Seed depth	1/4-1/2 inch
Seed germination	7-21 days depending on temperature and seed quality
Leaf harvest from seed	About 45-80 days
Leaf harvest from transplants	Usually 14-30 days after settling, depending on plant size
First leaf harvest size	When plants are about 6 inches tall
Spacing for leaf harvest	4-8 inches apart
Spacing for seed production	8-12 inches apart
Successive planting	Every 2-3 weeks for steady leaf supply
Seed/coriander harvest	About 90-100 days or roughly 2-3 weeks after flowering once seeds dry brown
Container depth	At least 8 inches; 10-12 inches better

Cilantro leaves and coriander seeds come from the same plant: *Coriandrum sativum*. The fresh leaves are called cilantro, while the dried seeds are usually called coriander.

3. Identification: Cilantro, Coriander and Culantro

Name	How To Identify It	Main Use
Cilantro	Soft, flat, parsley-like leaves with a fresh sharp smell. Older plants make thinner, feathery leaves when flowering.	Fresh leaves and stems for seasoning, salsa, soups and sauces.
Coriander	Round dry seeds formed after cilantro flowers. Seeds turn light brown when mature and dry.	Dry spice; can be used whole or ground.
Culantro / Chadon beni	Longer, tougher, saw-toothed leaves in a rosette, stronger flavor and better heat tolerance. It is a different plant from cilantro.	Strong Caribbean seasoning herb; often better for hot lowland conditions.

- If customers want soft leaves quickly, sell this as cilantro.
- If customers let it flower and dry seeds, they can harvest coriander seed.
- If customers ask for a heat-tough Caribbean herb, explain that culantro/chadon beni is different from cilantro.

4. Sunlight, Soil and Water

Cilantro grows best as a cool-season leafy herb. In Jamaica-style heat, the main goal is to slow bolting by keeping roots evenly moist and avoiding harsh afternoon sun.

Care Area	Target
Sunlight - cool/mild weather	6+ hours of sun can work well
Sunlight - hot weather	Morning sun + light afternoon shade
Best soil	Loose, rich, well-draining soil
Soil moisture	Evenly moist, not waterlogged
Container soil	Free-draining potting mix with compost
Watering in pots	Check daily in hot weather
Watering in ground	Water during dry spells; do not let plants wilt repeatedly
Mulch	Thin mulch layer to cool soil and reduce drying

Hot, dry conditions speed up flowering. A cooler spot with light shade at midday can give customers a longer leaf harvest.

5. Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	What To Do
At planting	Day 0	Mix compost into soil or use a fertile potting mix.
After settling	7-10 days after transplanting	Feed lightly only if leaves are pale or growth is slow.
Leaf harvest stage	Every 2-3 weeks if needed	Use mild liquid feed or compost support. Do not overfeed.
Bolting/flowering stage	When flower stalk rises	Stop pushing leaf growth; harvest leaves or allow seed crop.

- Cilantro is a short-term herb, so it does not need heavy feeding.
- Too much nitrogen can make soft growth and may reduce flavor quality.
- Feed lightly after the plant settles, not immediately after a stressful transplant.

6. Harvesting Guide

Harvest Type	Timing / Method
First leaf harvest	Start when plants are about 6 inches tall.
Cut-and-come-again	Cut outer leaves or stems; do not remove more than 1/3 of the plant at once.
Bunch harvest	Cut plant about 1 inch above soil and allow possible regrowth.
Harvest frequency	Every 3-7 days once plant is established and growing well.
Best harvest time	Early morning after leaves are dry.
Flower harvest	Flowers are edible and attract beneficial insects.
Coriander seed harvest	Collect seeds when they turn light brown and dry, usually 2-3 weeks after flowering.

For leaf customers, advise them to harvest often and replant every 2-3 weeks. For seed customers, allow plants to flower and dry.

7. Leaf Color and Problem Guide

Leaf Look	Possible Cause	What To Do
Bright green, flat leaves	Healthy leaf stage	Harvest often and keep watered.
Pale leaves	Low light, low nitrogen, overcrowding, root stress	Give brighter light, thin crowded plants, feed lightly.
Yellow lower leaves	Old leaves, overwatering, low nitrogen	Remove old leaves, check drainage, water evenly.
Brown leaf edges	Heat, drought, fertilizer burn	Shade from midday sun, water evenly, reduce fertilizer.
Thin feathery leaves	Bolting/flowering stage	Harvest quickly or allow seed production.
Spotted leaves	Bacterial leaf spot or fungal disease	Remove affected leaves, avoid wetting foliage, improve airflow.
Sticky curled leaves	Aphids/whiteflies	Check undersides and spray mild soap if needed.

8. Bolting, Flower Stalks and Coriander Seed

Bolting means cilantro is leaving the leafy stage and moving into flowers and seed. In hot weather this can happen quickly.

Sign	Meaning	Action
Plant stretches taller	Flower stalk starting	Harvest leaves immediately.
Leaves become fine/feathery	Bolting has started	Use leaves soon; flavor may become stronger.
Small white/pinkish flowers	Pollinator/seed stage	Leave some plants for bees and coriander seed.
Seeds turn light brown	Coriander seed is ready	Cut stems, dry in a paper bag, store dry.

To slow bolting: use morning sun and afternoon shade, keep soil evenly moist, avoid root disturbance, choose slow-bolt varieties where available, and plant small batches every 2-3 weeks.

9. Small Farmer Notes

Practice	Recommendation
Planting system	Use raised beds or well-drained rows.
Leaf spacing	4-8 inches apart depending on bunch size wanted.
Seed production spacing	8-12 inches apart for stronger seed heads.
Succession planting	Plant a new batch every 2-3 weeks for steady supply.
Heat management	Use afternoon shade or partial shade netting in hot periods.
Harvest handling	Harvest early morning; keep bunches shaded and cool.
Market quality	Sell bright green leaves; remove yellow or bolting stems if selling as leaf cilantro.

Important: for leaf production, cilantro is better managed as a quick, repeated crop instead of one long crop. Replanting small batches is more reliable than trying to keep one planting leafy for too long.

10. Home Garden Notes

Customer Situation	Recommendation
2-6 plants in pots	Use one 8-12 inch deep pot or separate small pots with drainage holes.
Kitchen garden	Place where plants get morning sun and light afternoon shade.
Continuous harvest	Replant every 2-3 weeks or let one plant seed itself.
If it bolts	Harvest leaves, use flowers, or let it make coriander seed.
If they dislike cilantro taste	Explain some people taste cilantro as soapy; coriander seed may still be useful.

- Keep containers close to the kitchen for regular harvesting.
- Use clean scissors for harvesting.
- Do not let pots sit in saucers of water.
- In hot weather, shade from 12 p.m. to 3 p.m. can help.

11. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Cilantro is a fresh herb that customers may eat raw, so clean handling is important from planting through harvest.

Sanitation Step	Why It Matters
Wash hands before handling seedlings or harvest	Reduces transfer of disease organisms and dirt.
Use clean scissors/knife	Reduces leaf rot and harvest contamination.
Do not harvest diseased leaves for customers	Protects quality and customer confidence.
Do not handle sick plants then healthy plants	Prevents spreading problems across trays or beds.
Keep pets/animals away from herb beds	Reduces contamination risk.
Rinse harvested leaves with clean water	Improves food safety before use.

Tobacco note: cilantro is not the main crop associated with tobacco mosaic virus, but growers should still wash hands after smoking or handling tobacco before touching any seedlings. This is a good general plant-health practice across herbs, peppers and tomatoes.

12. Hardening Off Seedlings

If the cilantro came from shade, greenhouse, nursery shelves, or protected trays, harden it off before full outdoor exposure.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade for 2-3 hours. Keep root ball moist.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 2-4 hours, then shade.
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus longer outdoor time. Avoid harsh midday sun.
Day 7	Transplant early morning or late evening.

- Cilantro has a taproot and dislikes rough transplanting.
- Do not let tray cells dry out during hardening off.
- If seedlings wilt badly, move them back to shade and water gently.

13. Transplanting from Trays or Small Pots

Cilantro is usually best direct-seeded, but customers may still buy seedlings. The key is to transplant gently and young.

Step	Instruction
1	Water seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.
2	Prepare holes first so roots are exposed for the shortest time possible.
3	Remove the seedling with the full root ball intact. Do not pull by the stem.
4	Plant at the same depth it was growing in the tray or pot.
5	Space 4-8 inches apart for leaves or 8-12 inches for seed production.
6	Water gently at soil level immediately after planting.
7	Give light shade for 1-3 days if conditions are hot.
8	Do not apply strong fertilizer for the first 7 days after transplanting.

Best time to transplant: before 8:30 a.m. or after 4:30 p.m. In hot weather, late evening is usually safer.

14. Common Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Aphids	Small insects on new growth, curling, sticky leaves	Spray with water or mild soap; repeat every 3-5 days; remove badly infested stems.
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly up when touched; yellowing/sticky leaves	Spray undersides; use yellow sticky traps; keep weeds down.
Cutworms	Seedlings cut off at soil line	Check at night; remove worms; use collars around young plants.
Armyworms/caterpillars	Chewed leaves, holes, black droppings	Handpick early morning/evening; remove damaged leaves.
Slugs/snails	Ragged holes, slime trails, worse after rain	Remove hiding spots; raise pots; check at night.

Cilantro flowers attract beneficial insects. If you have enough plants, let a few flower to support pollinators and helpful insects.

15. Common Diseases

Disease	Signs	Action
Powdery mildew	White powdery coating on leaves	Improve airflow; avoid overcrowding; remove affected leaves.
Bacterial leaf spot	Dark or water-soaked spots; spotting worse with wet leaves	Avoid overhead watering; remove affected leaves; increase spacing.
Damping off	Young seedlings collapse near soil line	Use clean mix; avoid overwatering; improve airflow.
Root rot	Yellowing, wilting, sour/wet soil smell	Improve drainage; reduce watering; avoid standing water.
General leaf rot	Slimy or rotting leaves near soil	Remove bad leaves; water at soil level; reduce crowding.

- Water early enough for foliage to dry before night.
- Do not crowd seedlings tightly after transplanting.
- Remove diseased leaves from the growing area instead of leaving them on the soil.

16. ParaLife Trees Support

Need help with your cilantro plant?

Send clear photos by WhatsApp so we can better understand the problem.

- The full plant from the side.
- Close-up of the leaves.
- Underside of affected leaves.
- The soil or container.
- Any insects, spots, or flower stalks you see.

Business	ParaLife Trees
Tagline	Planting a Life in Paradise
WhatsApp	1 (876) 372-7415
Best photo tip	Send one full plant photo + one close-up problem photo.

Sources used for this grow guide: University of Delaware Cooperative Extension; University of California Agriculture and Natural Resources; University of Wisconsin Extension; UF/IFAS Gardening Solutions; Royal Horticultural Society.